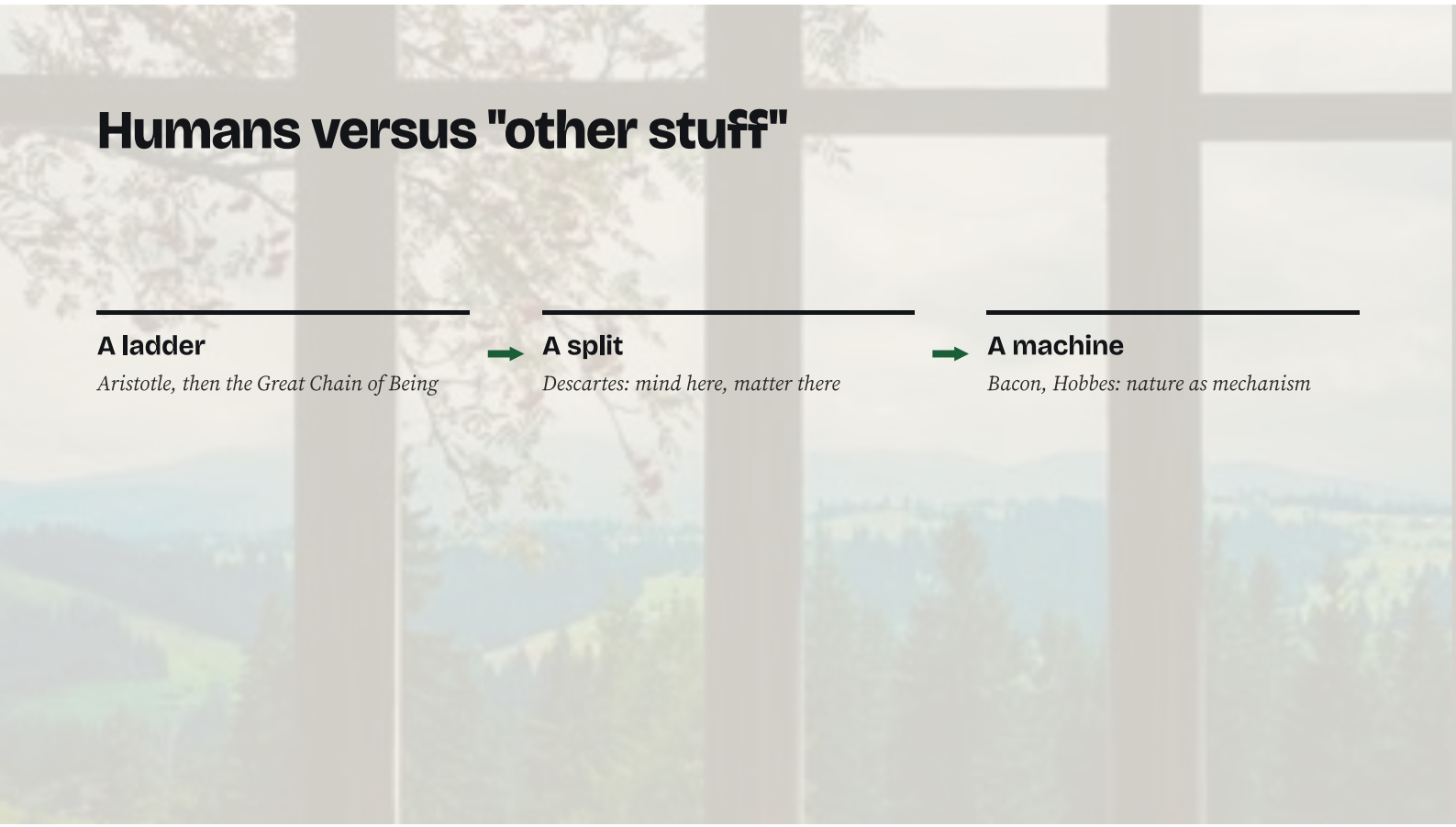
Hinduism, Buddhism and the Environment

What are the Hindu and Buddhist views of the environment?

Rik Hemsley

SLIDE 1

No notes



SLIDE 2

Aristotle's ranking of souls, plants, animals, humans: Middle Ages turned into the Great Chain of Being, God at the top, humans = runners-up.

Descartes' two substances, the thinking thing and the extended thing, with animals and our own bodies on the extended side.

Machine: Bacon and Hobbes, nature explained by mechanism, examined for our use.

Humans versus "other stuff"

A ladder → **A split** → **A machine**

Aristotle, then the Great Chain of Being | *Descartes: mind here, matter there* | *Bacon, Hobbes: nature as mechanism*



LYNN WHITE, 1967

"Despite Copernicus, all the cosmos rotates around our little globe. Despite Darwin, we are not, in our hearts, part of the natural process. We are superior to nature, contemptuous of it, willing to use it for our slightest whim. [...]
Zen Buddhism ... conceives of the man-nature relationship as very nearly the mirror image of the Christian view. ... I am dubious of its viability among us."

SLIDE 3

Lynn White had some limited info, but was interested.

Hinduism and Buddhism start from a diagnosis

THE ILLNESS	THE CAUSE	THE CURE	THE TREATMENT
Suffering	**Ignorance**	**Liberation**	**Practice**
Life caught in the round of rebirth, *saṃsāra*	A mistaken sense of self, craving	*Mokṣa* for Hindus, *nirvāṇa* for Buddhists	Insight, ethics, meditation, yoga

THEIR STARTING QUESTION

~~*What is nature, and where do we stand in it?*~~ **Why do we suffer?**

Their answer: we've mistaken what we are.

SLIDE 4

Epicurus and the Stoics: philosophy as a way of life (Pierre Hadot)

BTW Hinduism is an umbrella term for many traditions, no founde, no single creed...

Buddhism from ~ C5 BCE, kept karma, rebirth, liberation, denied the separate 'self'. Was/is cooler, except doesn't have the cool gods.

You are everything

UDDĀLAKA “Break the seed. What do you see?”

ŚVETAKETU “Nothing, sir.”

UDDĀLAKA “From that subtle essence this great banyan grows. That is the Self. That thou art.”

Chāndogya Upaniṣad 6.12, adapted

Brahman = **Ātman**

the ground of the world — the ground of you

SLIDE 5

Hindu texts: Upanishads, ~ 800 - 300 BCE.

Uddalaka is teaching his son Shvetaketu.

He has him fetch a fruit from a banyan.

"Break it. What do you see?" Tiny seeds.
"Break one of the seeds. What do you see?" "Nothing, sir."

"From that subtle essence you cannot see, this great banyan grows. That is the Self. That thou art"

Claim: The ground of everything, Brahman, and the ground of you, Atman, are one reality.

The Isha Upanishad opens: "All this, whatever moves in this moving world, is pervaded by the Lord. Enjoy it through renunciation; do not covet."

Spinoza (I think I missed where we talked about him)... one substance, God or Nature, with us as modes of it. Western "that thou art"?

Mystics, seeking the deeper reality that permeates and connects all creation (man!), are the other close cousin.

Arne Naess a Spinozist, Self-realisation idea partly from Gandhi - he quotes: "I believe in advaita (non-duality). I believe in the essential unity of man and, for that matter, all that lives."

Harming the world is harming yourself.

A wave in the ocean etc.

An order that is already moral

Ṛta: the order that turns the seasons is the order that tells you what is wrong.

EVERY BEING HAS ITS WAY

A lion killing isn't evil; it is its dharma.

After Pankaj Seth

TAKING OBLIGES GIVING BACK

Whoever enjoys what is given without giving back is a thief.

After Bhagavad Gītā 3.12

SLIDE 6

Vedas!

rta: the order of the world. The *one* order.

Turns the seasons, brings the rain, tells you what actions are 'wrong'

Ancestor of dharma: "the proper way of each being"

Bhagavad Gita on being a decent human being...

(Wikipedia:)
Hindu thought gives humans four aims:
Dharma (righteousness, moral values)
Artha (prosperity, economic values)
Kama (pleasure, love, psychological values)
Moksha (liberation, spiritual values, self-realization)

Seth: Cynical diagnosis of modern life: artha and kama now "stand alone".

But Dharma is considered more important than artha and kama.
And Moksha is supposed to be our goal as humans.

So we can plan artha and kama as long as we do enough dharma and get around to moksha at the last minute?

Week 2 - I wasn't there! - Greek split between physis, what grows, and nomos, human law and convention.

Rta: seasons and the right thing to do are one order... Hume's gap between is and ought?

A being's dharma: Aristotle's telos? part of a plant's or animal's telos is to be useful to humans... but A lion's *dharma* isn't

Naturalistic fallacy?
Dharma fixed caste, also blame Aristotle's ladder for fixing slaves and women? Argh.

The Gita: better to do your own dharma badly than another's well (3.35) ... law books tied each person's dharma to the caste and stage of life they were born into

Same as Aristotle's natural slave? Once nature sets the norms, whoever is on top can call the existing order natural. I think I said something on those lines last week.

Can you keep "every being has its own way" without "every person has their fixed place"?

Hindu: the world is already a moral order we belong to. Buddhist: same, but no "we", somehow.

You are no thing

“Just as, with an assemblage of parts, the word ‘chariot’ is used, so, when the aggregates are present, there’s the convention ‘a being’.”

The nun Vajirā, Saṃyutta Nikāya 5.10 (tr. Bhikkhu Bodhi)

When this is, that is.

From the arising of this comes the arising of that.

Dependent origination, *pratītyasamutpāda*

SLIDE 7

Chariot. Is it the wheel? The axle? Pile of parts?

You: body, feelings, perceptions, dispositions, consciousness?

Buddha's reply to the Upanishadic self, s'pose.

Dependent origination when this is, that is; from the arising of this comes the arising of that. Nothing exists by itself.

(But it is actually defined like "things which depend on things [Sankhata] depend on, er... things", which may just mean it's all a joke?)

Hume: there's only perception!

** Hinduism enlarges the self
** Buddhism dissolves it(!)

Heraclitus: you can't step into the same river twice. Buddha: and it isn't the same you doing the stepping.
Heraclitus: WTF are you doing here?

Buddhism: dependent origination to interbeing

5th century BCE	c. 150–250 CE	c. 700 CE	1240	1988
India	*India*	*China*	*Japan*	*Vietnam and France*
The Buddha	**Nāgārjuna**	**Fazang**	**Dōgen**	**Thich Nhat Hanh**
Dependent origination: how suffering arises	Nothing has an essence of its own	Indra's Net: each jewel reflects all the others	"The blue mountains are constantly walking"	"A cloud floating in this sheet of paper"

Recognisably ecological eventually?

SLIDE 8

Buddhist ideas got wider, more poetic, more connected to a recognisable world.

Dependent origination starts as chain of twelve links explaining how suffering arises. Nagarjuna gets all 'whoah, deep dude'.

Fazang invents Indra's Net: infinite net with a jewel at every knot, each reflecting all the others. Nightmare to clean. Demonstrated it to Empress Wu with a hall of mirrors (not the whole thing).

Dogen being Dogen...

Thich Nhat Hanh:

"If you are a poet, you will see clearly that there is a cloud floating in this sheet of paper."

No cloud, no rain. No rain, no trees. No trees, no paper.

Two roads, one place

WHERE WE STARTED
A self in here, a world out there

YOU ARE EVERYTHING
The self enlarged

YOU ARE NO THING
The self dissolved

SLIDE 9

Quick Recap

There is no word for “the environment”

Environment: that which environs. It needs a centre.

prakṛti	*jagat*	*loka*	*bhūta*
nature, including mind	the moving, you included	a world, defined by who lives in it	an element, and a being

HINDU
The centre is everywhere.

BUDDHIST
There is no centre.

SLIDE 10

Classical Sanskrit has no word for the environment. Why not?

Environment means that which environs: the surround. It needs something in the middle to be surrounded.

Now think about the two roads. Road one says the self is everything, so the centre is everywhere. Road two says there is no self, so there is no centre.

Either way, there's nothing for an environment to surround.

Look at the words we might reach for. Prakriti, usually translated nature, includes the mind.

Jagat, the moving, is the word in the Isha verse on slide 4, and it includes you.

Loka: "a world" - defined by being populated, though

Bhuta: an element and a being: one word for both.

* Prakriti - important

Descartes puts mind on one side and matter, including animal bodies, on the other.

Samkhya puts pure consciousness (purusha) against prakriti, (nature - includes intellect, ego and mind)

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Centre...

Pascal called nature "an infinite sphere, the centre of which is everywhere, the circumference nowhere". Solved it with maths, mate.

Ethics as a way of seeing

You don’t need a duty not to saw off your own leg.

ARNE NÆSS, 1986

“The requisite care flows naturally if the ‘self’ is widened and deepened so that protection of free nature is felt and conceived as protection of ourselves.”

WHY ARGUMENT ISN’T ENOUGH

Knowing doesn’t change behaviour. Something has to reach the body: pilgrimage, festival, fasting, meditation.

After Pankaj Seth

SLIDE 11

If there's no separate nature, then caring for it isn't a principle about how much it's is worth.

Ahimsa (don't harm) <-> Buddhist first precept (don't kill stuff)

Metta Sutta: "as a mother protects with her life her child, her only child, so with a boundless heart should one cherish all living beings".

Talk about craving as the engine of harm? Bit too likely to get into artha and kama, Zen

Seth: Decades of David Attenborough haven't changed how we behave, because knowing doesn't.

Practice might: pilgrimage, festival, fasting, meditation, trying not to be a shitty person.

-> Aristotle: we become just by doing just acts?

Back to ascetics? Use without greed or exploitation, Isha verse from slide 4: enjoy it through renunciation; do not covet.

Fasting and simple living were how they made it reach the body. The desert monastics who went out to contemplate nature have cousins in India's forest-dwelling renunciants.

Link to good life course? Buddhism = sharpest critique of desire-satisfaction accounts of well-being. Schumacher on economics: "the maximum of well-being with the minimum of consumption".

Non-duality makes an environmental stance unnecessary.

"Isn't that just self-interest?" Naess: yes... if we define the self to be everything (Naess drops the mic)

Bit judgy?

Schmithausen	The goal was escape from the world, not its flourishing.
Nelson	If the world is *māyā*, nature can become irrelevant.
Haberman	A worshipped river can be a polluted one.
After Ian Harris	Interdependence gives no “ought”: the bulldozer is dependently arisen too.



DELHI · CHHATH PUJA · NOVEMBER 2021

Worshippers bathe in the sacred Yamuna through a layer of toxic foam.

SLIDE 12

Sceptics time!

* Lambert Schmithausen (Hamburg)

Early Buddhist forests are frightening places to meditate in, sentience of plants is left as open question, not killing is not the same as protecting.

* Lance Nelson

If the world is maya - only Brahman is ultimately real ... consciousness primary (yay!), everything else is appearance.

Maybe don't get into Shankara's Advaita:
- Nature can become irrelevant
- only Brahman is ultimately real: undivided, unchanging consciousness.
- maya = the world of many separate things (rivers, trees, animals, people), appearance laid over Brahman because of ignorance. In dim light, coiled rope = snake. Dressing gown hanging on a door = burglar...

Sankara calls the world 'mithya': not _nothing_, but not real in the real... er, full sense.

Plato (week 2): if the Forms are what's real, the physical world is a shadow.

* David Haberman:

Yamuna is worshipped as a goddess _and_ grievously polluted. Emma Tomalin's point: religious environmentalism is partly a modern, Western idea read back into the tradition.

Some 'devotees': mother Ganges exists to wash away the impurities and pollution of earth, can cleanse herself!

Harsh: Reverence doesn't just fail to protect; it can get in the way.

The foam comes mostly from untreated sewage and industrial waste. English rivers are loved /and/ polluted too: sewage overflows into the Trent, farm run-off in the Wye...

The point is about reverence and protection, not about India.

"Surely not all Hindus call the world illusion?" yes... Ramanuja (not that one) treats the world as God's body... Tomalin's point: modern writers choose the strand that suits them. Fair enough, but it _is_ truth by choosing, like broadcast news.

Practical foundations for ecology, then?

PROVIDED

A diagnosis
The crisis is a crisis of the self

A relocation
From what nature is to what we are

Practices
That train how we see

MISSING

Institutions, policy or law

A magic way to win arguments as to why we shouldn't chop down forests.

Because being right doesn't help.

SLIDE 13

Schmithausen: Buddhist or Hindu environmental ethic is built from these resources.

True of every tradition, White's included: He said that St Francis "tried to depose man from his monarchy over creation".

Wk 2: Christianity already held more than dominion: stewardship, mysticism, asceticism.

Was White right?
Better at _what_?

Probably don't get into Alan Watts, deep ecology, Gary Snyder, ... Rousseau, (wk 3?) Idealising "natural" other as purer than us, old Western habit, Watts guilty.

Week 1 quiz scorecard

Cosmic wholeness	**Yes**	That thou art; Indra's Net.
Reciprocal duty	**Yes**	Taking without giving back is theft.
Moral equality for living things	**Not quite**	An animal birth is a bad birth.
Sustainability	**Not by itself**	A worshipped river can be a polluted one.

SLIDE 14

No notes

The Hindu and Buddhist views of the environment:

Distinct aspects and motivators

Hindu

Dharma: human responsibility
Ahimsa: all living things are sacred

Buddhist

The Yamuna test: can changed perception protect a river without institutions, or institutions without changed perception?

SLIDE 15

White hoped the East had a better view of nature and our place in it. What it has is some different viewpoint - different aspects.

Sources

TEXTS

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SLIDE 16

The Seth lecture is the main practitioner source; Nelson, Haberman, Schmithausen and Tomalin are the sceptics.